

Informing Public Finance Management in Somalia: A Contingent Evaluation of Social Protection & Service-Delivery Systems



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I. Executive summary

Background

Somalia adopted a federal system in 2004 and established District Councils (DCs) in 2016 under the Wadajir National Framework to decentralize governance and bring services closer to citizens (Somalia Stability Fund, 2020). However, service delivery in Somalia remains fragmented: most services are funded by NGOs and non-state actors, while informal clan-based networks provide social protection in the absence of formal government welfare systems (Karvinen, 2022). This study examines citizen perceptions of DCs, NGOs, and clan-based support to inform public finance management and resource allocation decisions.

Methods

We used data from 882 randomly selected survey respondents across four Somali districts (Adaado, Bosasso, Jowhar, and Marka). The multi-stage clustered sample, stratified by district, focused on urban centers where DC activity is highest. Data were collected through phone surveys following in-person household recruitment. We analyzed citizen perceptions of service providers (government, NGOs, private sector), trust in different levels of government, willingness to pay for health insurance and taxes, and the extent of clan-based financial support systems. Qualitative data were analyzed using conceptual content analysis and expert reviews. Statistical significance was tested to determine differences in responses by gender and other demographic factors when possible.

Results

Survey respondents expressed a strong preference for DC-provided services, with 75% preferring a government-run clinic to a private one and 83% believing government takeover of a private school would improve it. More so, over 81% expressed willingness to pay additional taxes for local services. Trust in government was high across all levels, but significantly higher at the district level. On clan-based support systems, only 31% of respondents make regular monetary contributions to their clan, though almost 75% believed their clan would financially support them in a medical emergency.

Conclusions

While respondents report strong preferences for government-led services and high willingness to pay, these findings may reflect aspirational demand for stability, government stewardship, or a rejection of an unstable status quo, rather than confidence in current government capacities. Trust in DCs is high, suggesting meaningful local legitimacy despite Somalia's limited state history. On clan-based financial support, regular contributions are less common than expected, suggesting that clan networks function more as on-demand relief systems than structured savings mechanisms. However, methodological limitations mean these results should be treated with caution.

I. Introduction

Somalia adopted a federal system in 2004 to prevent future centralization and bring services closer to the population. The formation of DCs in 2016 under the Wadajir National Framework for local governance to enhance accountability has propelled these decentralization efforts (Somalia Stability Fund 2020). However, there are limited studies on the perceived efficacy of these institutions. The DCs are composed of clan elders who proportionally represent the districts' clan demographics, with the authority to levy taxes and fund public goods (Karvinen, 2022). This report interprets survey responses within the context of fragile-state dynamics, where stated preferences may reflect normative expectations of the state rather than evaluations of current service delivery performance.

Somalia's decentralization necessitates a better understanding of DCs, which serve as the local government and provide goods and services that would typically fall under the federal government's purview. Consilient is conducting surveys in the Adaado, Bosasso, Jowhar, and Marka districts located in the Central, Northern, and Southern regions, respectively, to gauge citizens' perceptions of the newly established DCs. In this complex political environment where reliable data remain scarce, rigorous data collection remains critical, and our study aims to inform DCs on ways to improve decision-making and service delivery based on citizens' perceptions and stated needs.

To that end, this report presents new evidence from a survey of 882 Somali citizens across 4 districts about their level of trust in government, the extent of social protection through clan-based support, and their preference for the government to provide certain public services. We explore social protection systems and the extent to which they fill the gaps created by the federal government's delegation of authority to local governments. Some questions we explore:

- Given that most NGO aid services are integrated into the government's service provision, to what extent are citizens aware when a given service is actually coming from NGO/donor funding?
- Do citizens think that NGO programs are fair and/or efficient?
- Do citizens trust NGOs or private sector actors more than the government to deliver quality services?
- Who would citizens prefer as the main service provider- NGOs, the private sector, or the government?

This paper will be presented to the elected councilors of the surveyed districts to help them increase their awareness of and responsiveness to citizens' needs through policymaking, strategic project implementation, and efficient public spending.

II. Background

NGOs and Service Delivery

In Somalia, services are typically funded by NGOs and non-state actors (Hussein et al, 2026). Many non-profit NGOs and private-sector organizations operate in Somalia, providing services like education, healthcare, and other services in the government's stead. From our consultations with Consilient, we understand that this is largely due to the state and district governments operating on very tight budgets, with little flexibility for the deployment of services. Many NGOs directly fund government services and/or partner with the local government, so the aid is usually accredited to the local government (Karvinen, 2022). According to Consilient, while citizens pay taxes, it is challenging to know exactly who is providing and paying for a given service; the lines between NGO and government funding become blurred. This is compounded by the fact that private sector services, usually in the form of schools and clinics, fill the remaining gaps in service provision.

In this report, we explore how citizens perceive NGOs and private sector actors, and how they compare to the DCs in terms of service delivery and overall trust. Understanding how citizens perceive the quality of services from different actors will be important for DC members to improve their effectiveness in service delivery. If many citizens report that they prefer and trust the delivery of services coming from the DCs, they could use this as a basis to argue for more ownership and responsibility in service deployment from NGOs and aid groups.

Clan-Based support

Clans can provide different forms of support for their members, ranging from financial to relational (UK Department for International Development, 2013; European Union Agency for Asylum, 2023). This clan-based financial support serves as an alternative to a formal, large-scale welfare or public social protection system, of which there is none in Somalia (World Bank, 2018). Receiving financial support from clans is based on family or clan obligations, and community assistance norms are key drivers (UK Department for International Development, 2013).

Households belong to a clan, on which they can depend for social support or as a response to consumption shocks (World Bank, 2017; World Bank, 2018). Therefore, Somalia's economy and social fabric have evolved around social obligations, reciprocity, and clan solidarity rather than state-provided services (Bertelsmann Stiftung, 2024). However, these channels did not necessarily guarantee equitable coverage and access for everyone in need (especially urban versus rural communities) and were not shock-responsive (World Bank, 2018). There is also a lack of rigid standardized eligibility criteria or framework governing such financial contributions, or informal clan or community welfare systems

There is variation in how clans operate. In some cases, there is no formal eligibility checklist or process to qualify for support since referrals and local norms outweigh bureaucratic eligibility systems. Elders, respected lineage leaders, and influential family members often act as organizers of support, where they draw on long-standing norms of community support obligation and trust to decide when and how to distribute resources (UNDP Somalia 2025). The differences in eligibility factors for clan support range from need, severity, subclan, gender and age. This is also often underpinned by Islamic principles of charity and social solidarity (Bertelsmann Stiftung, 2024).

NGOs, clans, and DCs, while significantly different in their operations and formation, share a common function: providing services and support to citizens. By exploring citizens' perceptions of both institutions, we aim to understand the extent to which they step into the role traditionally played by the federal government.

Taxation in Somalia

Taxation is a fundamental component of state-building, serving as a mechanism for revenue generation and a means of establishing state authority and legitimacy (Tilly, 1992; Levi, 1988). In stable democracies, taxation serves as a social contract between citizens and their governments, where citizens pay taxes in exchange for public services, security, and governance. However, in conflict and post-conflict settings, this relationship fractures. Both state and non-state (including militia groups) compete to extract resources from the same population, creating parallel systems of taxation that challenge the state's monopoly on fiscal authority (Menkhaus, 2014; Melani, 2014).

After decades of civil war and state collapse, Somalia is working to rebuild governance institutions, including district councils (DCs) responsible for local tax collection. Since 2011, initiatives like the Local Development Fund have played a role in decentralization, shifting fiscal responsibilities from the central government to district councils and aiming to strengthen local governance and improve service delivery (Ncube, 2022). While tax collection is primarily paper-based, some district councils have adopted mobile-based tax payment systems that have tripled revenue in pilot areas (UN-Habitat, 2021). Yet Somalia's district councils face direct competition from Al-Shabaab, which also collects taxes across contested territories (Hansen, 2019; Menkhaus, 2014).

The literature highlights barriers to taxation efforts in Somalia's DCs, such as weak administrative capacity and poor legislation, paper-based tax collection, funding constraints, a large informal economy, and tax collection by the federal government and Al-Shabaab. Given these barriers, our study contributes to providing insight into how effective other agents of revenue collection and distribution, i.e., NGOs and clans, are in delivering services to citizens.

III. Literature review

Government-led Services in Somalia

It is essential to understand the scope of government-led services to accurately interpret respondents' answers regarding their preferences for hypothetical government-led social protection and service delivery scenarios. In practice, Somalia does not yet have a service delivery model in which the state fully finances, staffs, and directly provides most basic services across the country. Currently, the government plays different roles across sectors such as stewardship, regulation, contracting, coordination, and symbolic ownership, while actual delivery is frequently carried out by private providers, NGOs, community actors, or donor-supported implementing partners (World Bank, 2018; MoLSA, 2019).

This is expected because Somalia's fiscal base remains extremely constrained, as "domestic revenue-to-GDP ratio is about 2.5%, which is among the lowest in the world, and current resource levels are far below what would be needed to provide even basic education and health services at scale" (World Bank, 2024).

Similarly, Somalia's health system remains heavily dependent on non-state provision, with the World Bank estimating that at least 60% of health services are delivered by the private sector (World Bank, 2023). However, recent national health strategies place the government in a stronger stewardship role by defining priorities, coordinating partners, and increasingly using contracting arrangements in which public authorities oversee or contract providers to deliver the Essential Package of Health Services. The Somali Health Sector Strategic Plan for 2022 to 2026 presents this as a government-led reform agenda, even though implementation still relies heavily on donors, NGOs, and mixed provider arrangements (Ministry of Health and Human Services, 2021). In other words, in health, "government-led" often means state direction and public authority over the system rather than purely state-run service delivery in the classic sense (World Bank, 2018; Ministry of Health and Human Services, 2021).

Current Social Protection Landscape

Without a formalized social protection system led by the government (or any other official entities), Somalia's service delivery, local financial stability, and social protection have significant gaps. While the World Bank's report states that Somali citizens generally prefer public facilities, they are often forced to turn to private, NGO, or traditional providers for support, as public services are frequently unavailable or insufficient (World Bank, 2024; World Bank, 2018).

However, the government has worked to strengthen social safety nets through the **Baxnaano Program** of 2019. This program is Somalia's first large-scale and most direct contemporary example of a government-led social protection program. It provides unconditional cash transfers to poor and vulnerable households and includes a shock-responsive safety net element that scales up during crises. As described by the World Bank's results brief, "in the first two years of implementation, more than 1 million people received nutrition-linked unconditional cash transfers (UCTs) to meet basic consumption needs. Baxnaano's built-in shock-responsive features protected food security and livelihoods of an additional 600,000 people from a major 2020 locust outbreak through temporary scale-up of the regular program and delivery of emergency cash transfers (ECTs)" (World Bank, 2022).

Even in the positive case of Baxnaano, the program remains donor-financed, and the government's involvement is through a hybrid donor-government model (World Bank, 2020; World Bank, 2022). This could suggest that in Somalia, "government-led" efforts might refer to a hybrid model of institutional ownership, targeting authority, and state legitimacy rather than being solely funded and run by government actors. Respondents might interpret "government-led" as a model with "government involvement and authority".

Clan-Based Governance Systems

On the topic of clan-based financial systems as a form of social protection, research by Renders and Terlinden in 2010 described "Somaliland's post-1991 stability" as the product of a hybrid political order, where traditional clan institutions provided legitimacy, especially when formal institutions were too weak to stand alone. This, supported by other research by Menkhaus in 2007, provides a broader theoretical frame suggesting that zones of state failure are not "anarchic" and that communities forge their own governance systems to provide modest security and rule of law in the absence of a functioning state, and Somalia is an important example of this.

The DFID/GSDRC report on Somali networks (Hinds, 2013) grounds this by documenting the four main clan families and the customary law system governing collective obligation and compensation. The report emphasizes that these majority-clans exert dominance over minority groups and typically have access to more financial resources, which is an inequity somewhat visible in our own data, where dominant clan members report a higher likelihood of emergency financial support (79%) than non-dominant members (72%).

Furthermore, the research by Renders and Terlinden (2010) also noted that Somaliland's hybrid order eventually stopped being responsive and began to threaten local stability, which could signify that clan-based systems should be a complementary system rather than a permanent governance solution. This could also be reflected through the policy framing of our data findings.

Institutional Trust in Somalia

The empirical evidence on institutional trust in Somalia is mainly drawn from perception surveys and governance studies, which consistently show that trust varies significantly across institutions and is shaped by proximity, service delivery, and local engagement.

Data from the World Bank's Somali Social Contract and State-Building analysis shows that local governments and district councils often receive relatively higher trust ratings than federal institutions, largely due to their direct interaction with citizens and their role in visible service delivery (World Bank, 2024).

In the Somali Perceptions Survey conducted by Saferworld, citizens report moderate to high levels of trust in government institutions, particularly at the local level, despite widespread dissatisfaction with economic conditions and access to services (Saferworld, 2016). The survey highlights that trust tends to be higher for institutions that are more visible and accessible, such as district-level authorities, compared to more distant federal institutions.

According to the UNDP governance assessments in Somalia, many citizens express confidence in government institutions as symbols of order and stability, even while relying heavily on private providers, NGOs, or informal systems for essential services (UNDP, 2012). This suggests that institutional trust is not solely based on performance, but also reflects expectations about the state's role.

Research on Somali social organization emphasizes that clan networks continue to play a central role in providing security, dispute resolution, and social protection, often operating alongside or in place of formal institutions (UK Department for International Development (GSDRC), 2013). These systems are frequently viewed as more reliable in practice, particularly in contexts where state presence is limited. However, reliance on clan-based systems does not necessarily imply rejection of formal institutions.

Overall, the literature on institutional trust patterns and insights from Somalia highlight that institutional trust is complex, conditional, and context-based. It suggests that citizens usually express confidence in formal government institutions (especially at the local level) despite relying on informal or NGO systems for service delivery and social protection. This duality is critical for interpreting survey responses to understand that any preferences for government-led systems may be reflective of lived experiences with local governance, but also of broader expectations of government-intervention signaling overall stability, fairness, and coordination in a future Somalia.

Surveying in Post-Conflict Settings

Somalia is similar to other post-conflict regions, where adverse social and political issues linger even after peace agreements have been signed (Roll & Swenson, 2018). In such cases, researchers encounter obstacles to gathering necessary data in a timely, safe, and accurate manner. Most of these issues relate to access and quality, many of which are directly applicable to how our survey was conducted and the limitations that exist.

The most pressing obstacles researchers face in a post-conflict region are having safe and secure access to the entire population to conduct an unbiased, random sample (Roll & Swenson, 2018). Under ideal conditions, the researcher can travel throughout the region and interview subjects who would have little to no reason to decline. But when some regions of a post-conflict country are deemed inaccessible, the researcher must limit the scope of whom they can interview. This might skew results, since the sample consists of citizens residing in the accessible regions, who may be more homogenous in their experiences, their political beliefs, or their socioeconomic status within the country.

Researchers must be aware of how security issues limit the scope of their findings, but this should not prevent the researcher from conducting any work at all. In Somalia, regions outside of the major city centers are still politically unstable, and some are even contested by the Islamic group al-Shabaab, making any kind of research outside of the city centers extremely dangerous. As a result, our survey consists entirely of citizens within the city centers, inevitably skewing our results.

Limiting a survey to urban centers is common for conducting research in post-conflict states, and has its own set of biases by self-selecting the most elite members of the population. These urban elites can sometimes “be interested in the ‘official’ knowledge that the researcher produces”, that is, research consistent with their views that can be used “as a potential source of legitimacy for their position both domestically and internationally” (Rosenberg 2024). We should consider what kind of biases may exist within urban centers compared to rural regions of Somalia, especially regarding typical clan member behaviors and opinions on how active the District Council should be.

There is also the challenge of gaining trust in citizens to give truthful information, especially in the presence of foreign researchers. Citizens may be distrustful of foreign researchers arriving unannounced and asking intimate questions, which can cause a disturbance. This is not a problem for our survey, as our partner NGO Consilient works with local enumerators to carry out the sampling and surveying process.

While there are indeed challenges that come with any survey or research work in post-conflict settings, they are not ubiquitous to the situation in Somalia. The most prevalent issue in our case is limited access due to security concerns, thus creating a skew in the data towards urban centers that must be acknowledged when analyzing the results.

International Case Studies

- Stated & Perceived Preferences vs Actual Behavior

Upon reviewing other research done in fragile states, we noticed a recurring pattern that citizens often express strongly stated support for formal government institutions, even when those institutions are weak or contextually problematic.

Research by Casey, Glennerster, and Miguel in 2012 provides evidence of this in their randomized evaluation of the “GoBifo” community-driven development program in post-civil war Sierra Leone, where approximately \$4,667 worth of grants per village was paired with governance training and minority inclusion requirements. Despite short-run improvements in public goods provision and high stated support for formal institutions in the survey data, the intervention produced no long-term impact on the decision-making processes or the level of involvement of marginalized groups.

Furthermore, research by Holbrook and Krosnick in 2010 that used an “Item Count Technique” to test for social desirability bias across survey modes, found significantly higher overreporting of socially desirable responses in telephone surveys compared to internet surveys. They attributed this effect to the presence of an interviewer, even when it’s only over the phone. Given that our data were collected by phone, with enumerators previously introduced to household members in person, some portion of our results could also reflect respondents saying what felt socially appropriate or “desirable”, not just what they believed.

Overall, these research observations argue for interpreting high stated preferences as a signal of demand and aspiration rather than a direct measure of institutional confidence.

- Willingness to Pay in Fragile & Low Income Contexts

To better contextualize and understand willingness-to-pay survey results, we looked at research by Amugsi et al. (2017), which used contingent evaluation, randomly selected respondents, t-tests and linear regressions, and found that 68% of public servants in Juba City in South Sudan, indicated willingness to pay for a proposed National Health Insurance Fund, even though government health spending had collapsed from 8.4% to 2.2% of the national budget between 2007 and 2012. Out of those who indicated willingness to pay, over two-thirds preferred a premium of up to 5% of monthly income.

In another international case, Rwanda's Mutuelles de Santé program, which was introduced in the late 1990s after the genocide, community-based health insurance schemes with government backing reached 85% of the population by 2008, with Schneider and Diop (2001) documenting that even non-enrolled households expressed a strong desire to join despite doubts about their ability to afford the annual fee. Together, these cases suggest that high WTP (willingness to pay) stated in surveys, for government-led health schemes in post-conflict or low-income contexts, is not irregular.

- NGO vs Government Service Delivery Preferences

A distinction that runs through the fragile-state service delivery literature that is essential for reading our results correctly is the gap between “normative preference” and “performance evaluation”. Normative preference refers to who citizens believe should be responsible for delivering a service, while performance evaluation refers to how well citizens think that provider is currently doing so.

The World Bank's Iraq Systematic Country Diagnostic (2017) documents that despite fewer than 30% of citizens reporting satisfaction with electricity and water provision, a majority still held the state responsible for delivering those services, expressing a claim about legitimacy rather than a judgment about capacity.

In the case of Lebanon, we see the same dynamic in a different form through the World Bank's Social Impact Analysis of the electricity and water sectors (2009), which found willingness to pay for improved government supply to be high even among households that were heavily reliant on private generator operators. We can conclude that the Lebanese were carrying the cost of the state's failure to provide electricity while continuing to believe that the state owed them better service provision.

IV. Description of Data and Methods

The surveys were conducted among a sample of individuals living in the district capital and its immediate urban environment, focusing on outcome indicators such as citizens' perceptions of DCs, attitudes towards taxation, and the scope and efficiency of social protection schemes, and NGO service delivery. These regions are more accessible and tend to have the highest DC activity, which makes them more viable for conducting the surveys.

For this survey, Consilient did not sample in rural areas for cost reasons, and we acknowledge that this poses limitations for the sample's representativeness to the larger Somali context and generalizability of our findings. Survey responses reflect the views of residents in the urban district capitals only and should not be extrapolated to the broader district population, to rural communities, or to Somalia as a whole.

The sampling process is a multi-stage clustered sample, stratified by district (or, rather, town). Sampling is a two-step process. The first stage consists of recruiting households in person. The second stage consists of randomly calling households to conduct phone surveys. *The household recruitment is as follows:*

1. Define the boundaries of the district capital in QGIS / Google Earth.
2. Select starting points randomly over the surface of the polygon resulting from #1
3. Assign those starting points randomly to enumerators, who travel to those locations.
4. From the points (they must be within 50 meters of the assigned starting point), they indicate which cardinal directions (N/S/E/W) are safe to travel and take them in the direction of residential homes.
5. ODK Collect assigns them a walking direction randomly, from those they identified as eligible in the previous step.
6. They proceed with a "random walk," during which they recruit every third household on the left as they walk.
7. When reaching a juncture, they continue straight or (if that is not possible), alternate right and left turns.
8. Compiling the phone numbers of every adult member who is willing to participate

The phone surveys are conducted as follows:

9. Randomly calling collated phone numbers
10. Calling each number at most 4 times, spread over three days

This process produces a fairly representative sample of households in the district capital. Many of the main criticisms of the “random walk approach to sampling” focus on the extent to which it gives enumerators discretion, which can introduce bias (e.g., they skip a household that looks unfriendly; Consilient chooses a starting point that is in a nicer part of the neighborhood, etc.).

They try to remove as much of this discretion as possible by:

- Assigning randomized starting points
- Randomizing walking direction
- Checking whether the random walk approach appears to have been followed, to the best they can tell, from satellite imagery

In past Consilient surveys, some regions have had larger and more representative samples than others. To mitigate sampling issues, Consilient worked to standardize the number of respondents in each district. We also tailored the questions on clans with cultural sensitivities in mind to gain responses to as many questions as possible, as some might be hesitant to share information on

In addition to the new data collected, we will pull from the standard initial questions used in Consilient’s previous surveys (age, sex, etc) to collate demographic information, which we can use to aggregate data, in analyzing NGO and clan support.

Summary of Respondents

Through the sampling method described, Consilient reached out to 2,389 households for survey responses, of which only 882 ended up completing the entire survey, almost 37% of the total sample pool. While low, this response rate is in line with other phone surveys conducted in Africa, with the Afrobarometer phone survey typically achieving a 30-50% response rate (Opoku Asare et al. 2017).

While we do not have sufficient data on the district populations to test for representativeness, we can compare the sampled population with the surveyed population. The table below shows [summary statistics](#) for all of those sampled, compared to only those surveyed. After running a chi-square test, we see a significant difference between respondents and the total sample pool by district. We also ran t-tests and found significant differences at the 5% level in the mean ages between those surveyed and sampled in Jowhar and Marka. We also see a significant difference in the gender ratio in Adaado at the 5% level.

Table 1: Sample statistics

	Surveyed					Sampled				
	<u>Adaado</u>	<u>Bosasso</u>	<u>Jowhar</u>	<u>Marka</u>	Total	<u>Adaado</u>	<u>Bosasso</u>	<u>Jowhar</u>	<u>Marka</u>	Total
N	223 (25.3%)	187 (21.2%)	220 (24.9%)	252 (28.6%)	882 (100%)	581 (24.3%)	744 (31.1%)	619 (25.9%)	445 (18.6%)	2,389 (100%)
Average Age	33.26 (10.37)	28.89 (10.91)	32.59 (11.01)	31.69 (12.79)	31.72 (11.47)	34.29 (12.37)	28.89 (11.20)	34.57 (13.15)	33.27 (14.14)	32.49 (12.81)
% Female	0.520	0.540	0.505	0.492	0.512	0.451	0.503	0.530	0.488	0.494

To address these differences, we have used inverse probability weights to make the results of the surveyed population more representative of the sampled population by gender and district. While differences are minute, all results discussed below will be of the weighted results.

Given these significant differences and the low response rate, we believe there is some respondent bias between those who completed the survey and those who did not. While it is unclear why exactly there is respondent bias, our current hypothesis is that there might be self-selection bias— those who care more about government service delivery are more likely to devote time to answering survey questions on the subject. If this were true, we should consider our results as an overestimation of the general population's opinions on district councils and their service capacities.

We received responses from members of over 50 different clans, with the two largest coming from the Habar Gedir - Saleeban (21% of respondents) and Biyomaal (almost 17% of respondents). Our analysis includes results on the two largest districts, since the smaller districts have significantly fewer respondents, as well as results for everyone from the “dominant” clan of each district, as presented to us by Consilient. This was coded as a binary equaling 1 if a respondent is from a clan that is considered dominant in the district they came from.

V. Results

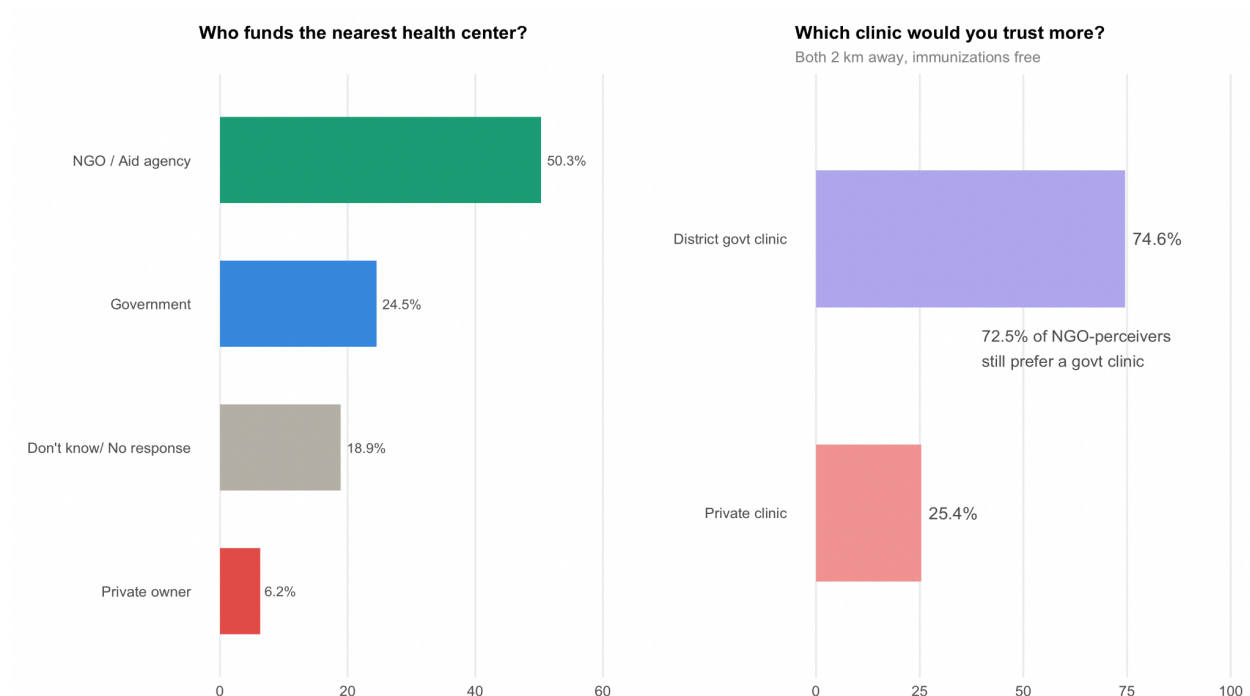
Before analyzing the data, our main hypothesis for Research Question 1 was that citizens were expected to show stronger trust in and preference for NGO/private delivery of services over government provision since it already is the current status quo of the service-delivery landscape in these districts. As for Research Question 2, the hypothesis was that we expected clan-based financial support systems to be regular, widespread, and favored by respondents, with an even stronger preference demonstrated amongst older respondents.

Service Provision Questions

We asked respondents to think about the closest maternal and child health center to their home and asked who they think funds that center. While we cannot say for certain what the correct answer is for each respondent, 49.9% of respondents stated it was an NGO or aid agency, 25.3% stated it was the government, 6.8% said a private owner, and the remaining 18% were not sure. If we assume respondents have somewhat accurate information, this gives us a general sense of the landscape of service providers.

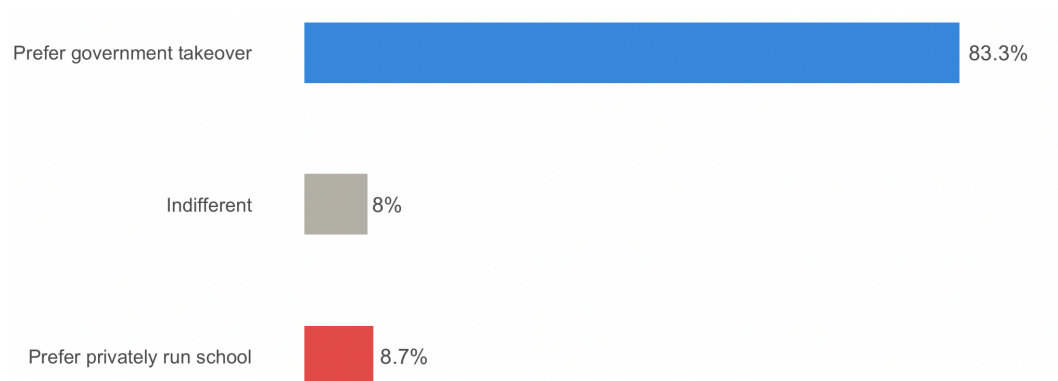
We then asked a hypothetical scenario, as shown by [Figure 1](#), where two equidistant health clinics are offering free immunizations; the only difference is that one is privately run, and the other is run by the district council. 75% of the respondents said they would prefer to go to the council-run clinic over the private clinic. It is important to note that after conducting this survey, we realized that there may have been confusion as to whether an NGO/Aid agency clinic would fall under “private clinic” or “district government clinic”. Our intention was for NGO/aid agencies to fall under private, but it is unclear if this was translated during the surveys.

Figure 1: Health centers are predominantly NGO-funded, yet most prefer government-run care



Another scenario was presented where we asked how respondents think the nearest privately run school would fare if its operation was taken over by the district council. [Figure 2](#) shows the responses, with 83% saying it would be better, 8% saying it would stay the same, and 9% saying it would be worse.

Figure 2: Strong public support for government takeover of private schools



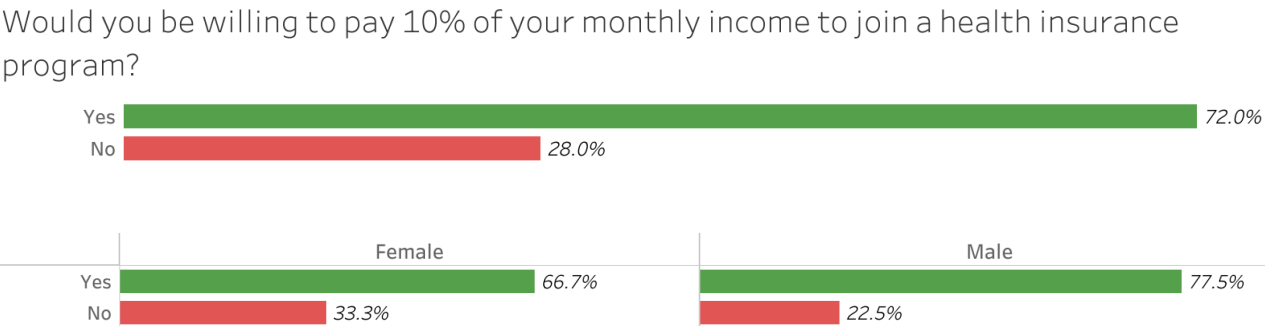
Survey data, Adaado, Bosasso, Jowhar and Marka districts, 2026, n = 882. Results are weighted using inverse probability weights

From these questions, we see that there is a moderate level of awareness that most social services are privately run, either through aid agencies or private companies. Furthermore, there is a desire for the district council governments to provide these services instead. It is unclear whether the government has the capacity to provide these services, but the public believes that government-run services would be better than how things are run today.

Health Insurance, Trust and Taxes

We asked respondents to imagine a health insurance program where citizens could pay 10% of their income a month to get free services at government clinics, as shown in [Figure 3](#). Nearly 72% of respondents said they would be willing to pay for this service. Of those who declined, very few changed their mind when asked if they’d pay 5% of their income. Aggregated across gender, the data indicates more reported willingness amongst men to contribute a portion of their income to enroll in a health insurance program (77.5%) versus women (66.7%).

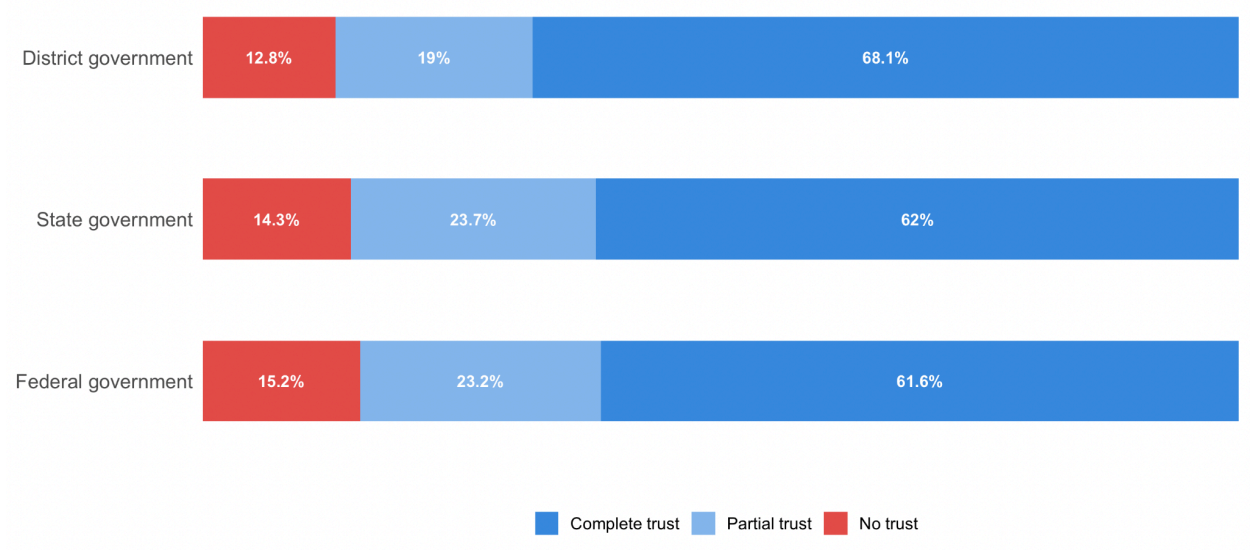
Figure 3: Willingness to pay for a health insurance program



Survey data, Adaado, Bosasso, Jowhar and Marka districts, 2026, n = 882. Results are weighted using inverse probability weights

We then asked how much citizens would trust the program to be properly run by the district council, state government, and federal government. While answers vary between respondents, we see 86% trusted the district council, 85% trusted the state, and 82% trusted the federal government. Using a Wald test, we group the responses into a binary: those who trust the government to any degree vs those who do not trust at all. We find a significant difference in the level of trust between the District and Federal governments at the 5% level, and a significant difference in the level of trust between the State and Federal governments at the 10% level.

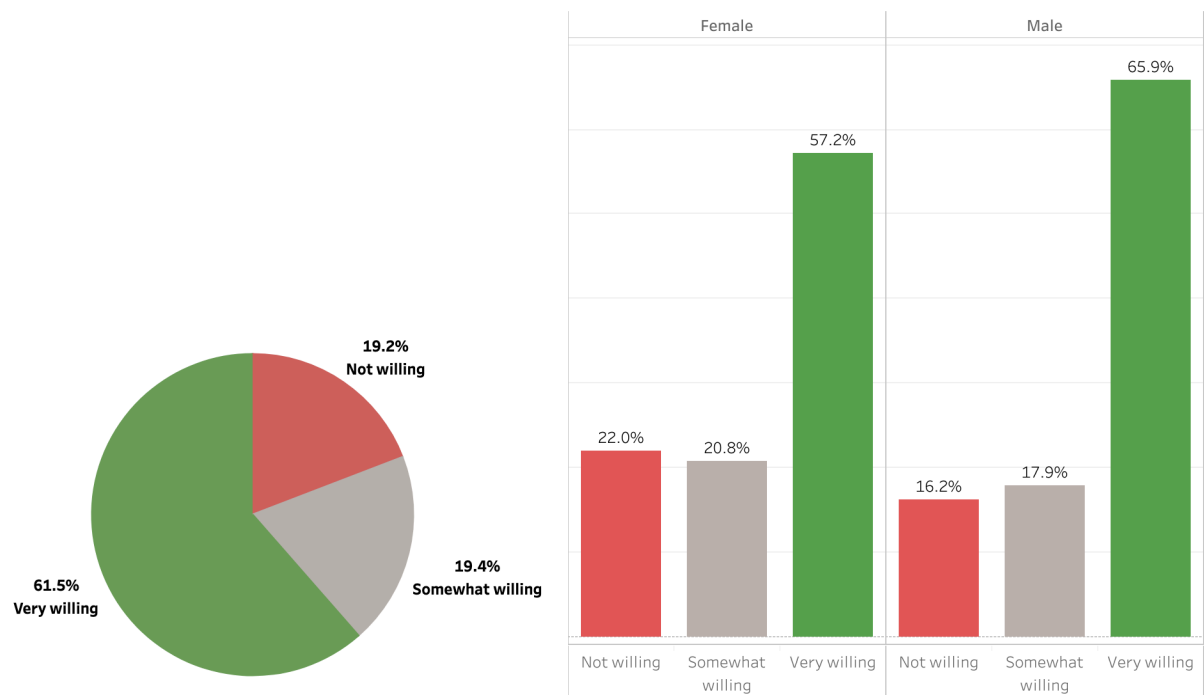
Figure 4: Trust in each level of government to manage a health insurance program



Survey data, Adaado, Bosasso, Jowhar, and Marka districts, 2026, n = 882. Results are weighted using inverse probability weights

Finally, we asked citizens how willing they would be to pay additional taxes to support local government services; 62% were very willing, and 19.5% were somewhat willing. We show these responses, disaggregated by gender, in Figure 5 below and find a significant difference at the 5% level.

Figure 5: Willingness to pay taxes to support local government services



Survey data, Adaado, Bosasso, Jowhar, and Marka districts, 2026, n = 882. Results are weighted using inverse probability weights

As previously stated, we see there is demand for additional social services provided through the district council and a willingness to pay taxes so they can happen. Not only this, there is relatively high trust in the government to provide these services at any level, with the highest being at the most local level.

Clan Relations and Monetary Systems

The next section of the survey asked respondents about their clans and what monetary systems exist within them. We received answers from members of over 50 different clans, making clan-level comparisons difficult to draw with confidence. Regardless, the answers provide some possible insights into clan member behaviors in Somalia.

We started by asking respondents if their clan elders ask them to make regular monetary contributions to the clan in order to pay for members' needs. Only 31% of respondents said yes. Of this 31%, 71.2% were male, and 28.8% were female, a statistically significant difference, as shown in [Figure 6](#).

Figure 6: Contribution frequency

Do your clan elders ask you to make regular financial contributions to the clan?



Survey data, Adaado, Bosasso, Jowhar and Marka districts, 2026, n = 882. Results are weighted using inverse probability weights

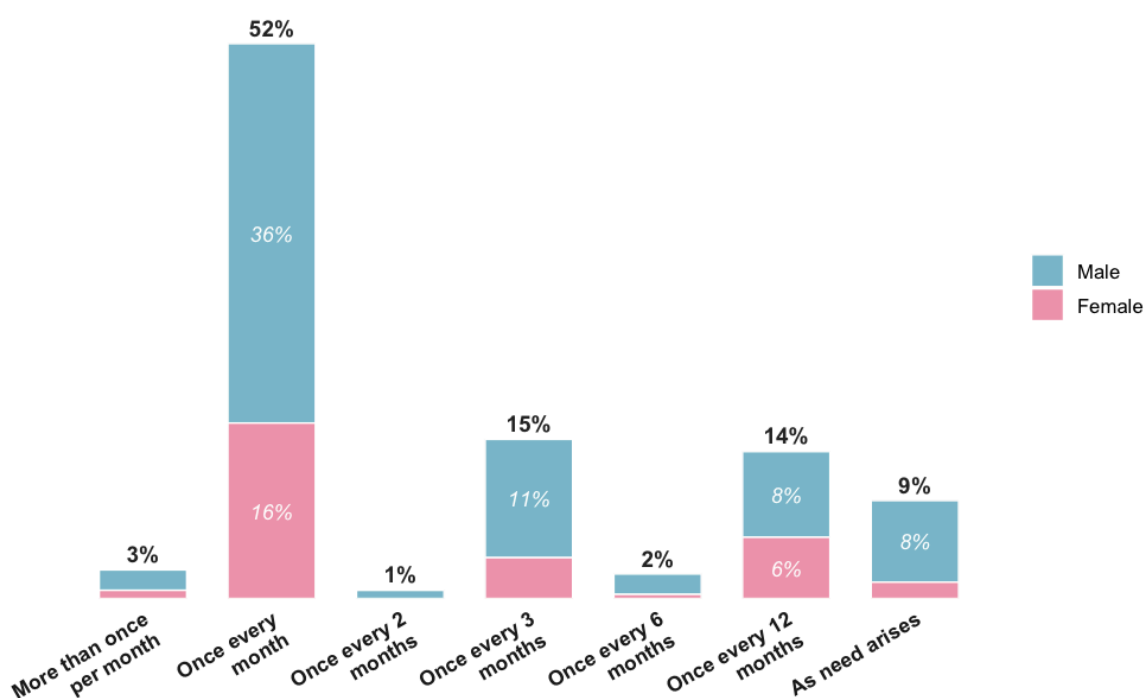
There is also a significant difference in the mean age between those who contribute regularly at 34 and those who do not at 30, at the 1% level. Finally, we see a large difference in the average income between those who contribute regularly and those who do not. When unweighted, we see average incomes of \$171 and \$142, respectively, a significant difference at the 10% level. However, adding the weights changes these averages to \$187 and \$154, which have a p-value of 0.1109, just shy of statistical significance at the 10% level. While the weighting is changing the average incomes to be more representative of the entire sampled population, we see this is still a real difference between those who regularly contribute and those who do not, despite not being significantly different.

Disaggregated by clan, we find that 29% of members of the Habar Gedir clan, and 21.4% of members of the Biyoomal clan, and 28.5% of those from Dominant clans overall make regular contributions to their clans. The p-value on the difference between Dominant and non-Dominant clans is 0.1003, just shy of statistical significance.

We then asked those who said yes a series of follow-up questions regarding the specifics of their clan contribution habits. 84% of these respondents stated that it is common for all men to make such a regular contribution, while 61% said all or some women make these contributions. For Dominant clans, we see that 56% say all or some women make these contributions, but this result is not statistically significant.

We also asked how frequently they contribute and how much. [Figure 7](#) shows contribution frequencies, with the most common being once every month at 52% of regular contributors.

Figure 7: Frequency and amount distribution of contributions by gender



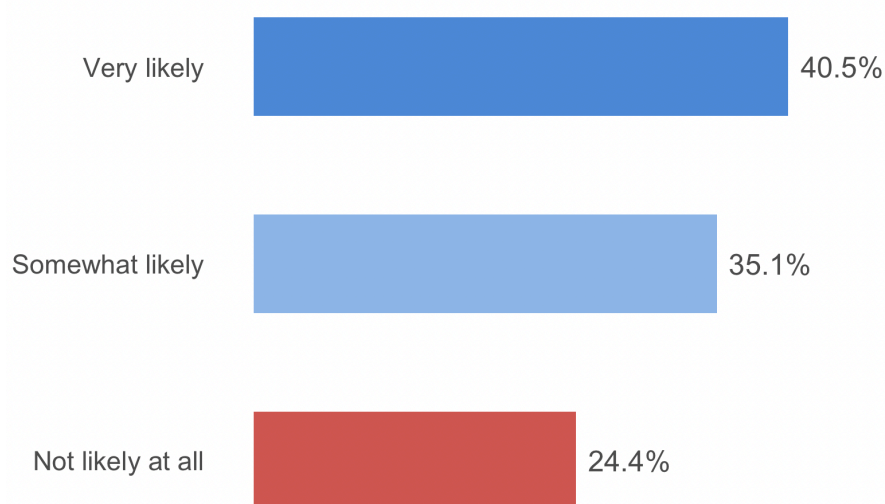
Survey data, Adaado, Bosasso, Jowhar and Marka districts, 2026, n = 882. Results are weighted using inverse probability weights

Among the 30% who contribute to the clan (n=261 out of 882), the median contribution is \$10 per occasion, representing approximately 8% of monthly income. However, the mean (\$30.79) suggests significant variation, and some respondents report contributions exceeding their total reported income, indicating likely recall or social desirability bias in self-reported amounts.

The phrasing of our questions may have led to inaccurate results. There is a distinct difference between paying for someone's emergency and making a regularly scheduled contribution for no immediate reason. Therefore, someone can state “No, I do not make regular contributions” and still donate to clan members throughout the year. Thus, we believe that reframing the original question as “Have you made any financial contributions to members of your clan in the last year?” could have yielded clearer responses.

After this series of questions, we presented a scenario in which the respondent needed money for a medical treatment they could not afford on their own. How likely is it that the clan would support them? Almost 75% of respondents stated it was at least somewhat likely they would receive support, as shown in [Figure 8](#).

Figure 8: Likelihood of financial support from the clan



Survey data, Adaado, Bosasso, Jowhar and Marka districts, 2026, n = 882. Results are weighted using inverse probability weights

When we analyzed the results for the two largest clans, we see that 80% of the Biyomaal Clan respondents say the clan is very or somewhat likely to support them in an emergency. Similarly, 80% of the Habar Gedir respondents say very or somewhat likely — neither difference is statistically significant. Analyzing the results across all Dominant clans shows significant differences at the 5% level between the stated likelihood between Dominant clan members (79%) and non-Dominant clan members (72%).

VI. Discussion

As mentioned above, there are a few reasons to believe that there may be bias in our survey responses before explaining what the results could mean. The sampling process itself was limited to the urban centers and thus is not entirely representative of the entire district. Of everyone sampled, only 37% completed the survey. We see several significant differences between the surveyed and sampled populations, including the overall breakdown of respondents by district, the average age in districts Jowhar and Marka, and the gender ratio in district Adaado. While we do not know for sure, we hypothesize that those who answered the survey are more likely to have stronger opinions on government, and therefore more willing to answer questions. The survey also took place during the month of Ramadan, which could have made respondents less available to respond. Given these caveats, we analyze the data with caution, but still believe it can provide value to Consilient and the District Councillors.

Despite Somalia's historically limited state capacity and fragmented service delivery, the survey respondents expressed a strong preference for government-led social protection and safety nets. A large number of respondents also indicated a willingness to contribute up to 10% of their monthly income to enroll in such systems. Similarly, respondents expressed a preference for government involvement in providing essential services, such as healthcare and education. Studies show that the financing of public goods through informal taxes strengthens citizens' perceptions of the local state and its legitimacy (van den Boogard 2021). This could partly be because citizens in fragile contexts have relatively low expectations about what the government should do. Instead of expecting the government to deliver services directly, citizens may see the government's role as primarily facilitating or lobbying for development (van den Boogard 2021).

One of the most striking findings of this survey is that 83.3% of respondents expressed a preference for District Council takeover of privately-run schools. This directly contradicts our initial hypothesis for the first Research Question, which anticipated a stronger citizen preference for NGO and private service delivery given the historically limited capacity of local government institutions in Somalia. One plausible interpretation is that this preference reflects aspirational demand where citizens are not necessarily endorsing current DC performance or being explicitly "pro-government", but signaling a desire for a functioning formal government to assume responsibility for service delivery.

These findings are consistent with the literature reviewed on stated preferences in post-conflict settings, where citizens frequently express pro-government attitudes that reflect frustration with the status quo rather than demonstrated confidence in state institutions. In fragile and conflict-affected contexts like Somalia, the literature shows that when informal systems are inconsistent, citizens may express support for alternative systems as a form of aspirational preference rather than based on lived experience. Therefore, it could be suspected that “government-led” preferences may be less of a concrete institutional choice or an indicator but rather a reflection of the respondent’s preference for stability, predictability, and fairness. With this in mind, we analyze our results cautiously, noting that citizens’ preference for the government to provide public services might actually signal low expectations rather than high regard for government efficiency.

It was also demonstrated that many respondents believe that their clan would offer them financial support should an emergency arise. Originally, we hypothesized that it would be much more common for all citizens to contribute a regular, standardized amount of money to be distributed throughout the clan. Instead, we find that less than a third of respondents donate or financially contribute to their clan on a regular schedule. Regardless of the individual contribution of each member, over 70% of respondents trust that they would receive financial support if they asked or needed it.

At this time, we are looking through the data more to see if there are any significant differences between those who give regularly and those who do not. So far, we have found that those who contribute regularly are statistically more likely to be male, somewhat older, and have somewhat more income. With this in mind, we hypothesize that clan-based financial support systems serve the purpose of providing immediate financial relief should someone need it, with some members of the clan providing more support than others, potentially depending on one’s gender, age, and own financial situation.

VII. Conclusion

Despite only existing for a few years, there are high levels of trust in the District Councils, significantly higher than trust at the federal level. Citizens report relatively high trust that the District Councils can take over the currently offered education and healthcare services (whether indicative of perceived legitimacy or demonstrated government capacity). Furthermore, respondents state a willingness to pay taxes so that such services can exist. Regardless of whether DCs truly have the capacity to take on such services, the level of trust exceeded our expectations.

Moreso, clan-based financial support is not as regular or standardized as we hypothesized. Some clan members report larger-than-average donations monthly, while some report giving a small amount of support once a year. Furthermore, some clan members may be more likely to give support than others.

With such large standard deviations, we are reluctant to make any strong assertions on clan practices as a whole. However, we still see that most clan members would expect to receive financial support should they need it in an emergency. The responses suggest that some clan members are willing to make such contributions when there is actually a need for it. Beyond this immediate need, clan members are either unable to afford to make regular contributions or see no need to do so.

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